

RE Data Metrix

Developer Brief

Onboarding UX — Priority Fixes

Prepared: April 2026
For: Replit Development Team
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Priority: **High — implement before any pricing model changes**

1. Background & Problem Statement

RE Data Metrix is a SaaS platform for real estate investors, offering automated deal analysis, lender search, and investment calculators. The platform has attracted organic free-account sign-ups, but engagement data shows that zero organic users have run a deal analysis — the core tool the product is built around.

A UX audit of the free user login journey identified two specific drop-off points that are almost certainly responsible for this zero-engagement result. Both are fixable with targeted code changes. This brief describes each issue, the desired behaviour, and acceptance criteria.

2. Issues Identified

Issue	Description
Issue #1	Free users are redirected to the /upgrade pricing page immediately on first login, before seeing any product
Issue #2	The Deal Analysis page shows an "Unlock Full Results / View Plans" upgrade prompt before the user has entered any data or seen any output
Issue #3	The "Start Deal Analysis" card on the dashboard has equal visual weight to five other cards, giving new users no clear starting point
Issue #4	There is no Day 1 onboarding email directing new users back into the product after sign-up

3. Detailed Requirements

Issue #1 — Remove First-Login Redirect to /upgrade

Current behaviour:

When a free account user logs in, they are immediately redirected to redatamatrix.com/upgrade. This is a full-page pricing screen showing plan options. The only way to reach the dashboard is to actively click "Continue with Free Account" at the bottom of the upgrade card.

This is the first thing a new user sees after signing up. Many are abandoning here without ever seeing the product.

Required behaviour:

- On login, all users — including free accounts — should land directly on the dashboard (</portal/dashboard>).
- Do not redirect free users to </upgrade> on login under any circumstance.
- **Optional:** A slim, dismissible banner at the top of the dashboard may be shown to free users highlighting upgrade benefits. This must be dismissible with a single click and must not block access to any feature.
- **The </upgrade> page should only be surfaced when:** (a) the user clicks an explicit "Upgrade" button or nav link, or (b) the user attempts to use a feature that requires a paid plan (e.g. saving a deal, exporting a report).

Acceptance criteria:

1. A free account user logs in and lands on </portal/dashboard> without any redirect.
2. The </upgrade> page is NOT shown automatically at any point during the login flow.
3. Any optional upgrade banner is dismissible and does not reappear once dismissed in the same session.

Issue #2 — Move Upgrade Prompt on Deal Analysis Page

Current behaviour:

On the Deal Analysis page (</m/deal-analysis>), free users see an "Unlock Full Results — Subscribe to see detailed lender comparisons" block with a "View Plans" button at the bottom of the page — before they have entered any deal data or seen any results.

This presents a paywall before the user has experienced any value. The user is being asked to pay for results they have not yet seen.

Required behaviour:

- Remove the "Unlock Full Results" block from the initial Deal Analysis page view.
- The upgrade prompt should appear only after **the user has submitted their first deal analysis and is viewing their results**. At that point, show partial results for free users and surface the upgrade prompt contextually — e.g. blurred/locked lender comparison rows with an inline "Upgrade to see full lender comparison" message.
- The goal is: user enters data → user sees partial results and understands the tool works → user is motivated to upgrade to see the rest. Not: user arrives → user sees paywall → user leaves.

Acceptance criteria:

4. A free user landing on the Deal Analysis page sees no upgrade prompt, paywall, or "View Plans" button before submitting a deal.
5. After submitting a deal, the free user sees results. Paid-only elements (e.g. full lender comparison) are clearly indicated as upgrade-gated, inline with the results.
6. An upgrade CTA appears contextually within the results view, not as a page-level block before any interaction.

Issue #3 — Elevate "Start Deal Analysis" on the Dashboard

Current behaviour:

The dashboard displays six cards in a 2-column grid: Start Deal Analysis, Deals Analyzed, Tools & Resources, Search Lenders, Saved Lenders, and Refer a Friend. All six cards are visually identical in size and weight. A new user has no visual cue that "Start Deal Analysis" is the primary action.

Required behaviour:

- Make "Start Deal Analysis" the visually dominant element on the dashboard for users who have zero deals analyzed.
- **Suggested implementation:** Display it as a full-width card at the top of the dashboard (spanning both columns), with a distinct background colour (navy or teal), white text, and a prominent CTA button. Update the copy to: "Start Here — Analyze Your First Deal in 3 Minutes."
- Once the user has run at least one deal analysis, **revert the card to its standard size and weight**. The elevated treatment is for first-time / zero-deal users only.

Acceptance criteria:

7. A user with 0 deals analyzed sees a full-width, visually distinct "Start Deal Analysis" card at the top of the dashboard.
8. A user with 1+ deals analyzed sees the standard dashboard layout with equal-weight cards.

Issue #4 — Day 1 Onboarding Email Trigger**Current behaviour:**

After a user signs up and verifies their email, no follow-up communication is sent directing them back into the product or guiding them to take their first action.

Required behaviour:

- **Trigger 1 (Day 1):** Send an automated email within 24 hours of email verification. Subject: "Your first deal analysis is ready — here's how to run it." Body should include a single prominent CTA button linking directly to /m/deal-analysis.
- **Trigger 2 (Day 7):** If the user has not run any deal analysis by Day 7, send a follow-up email. Subject: "You haven't run a deal yet — try this sample property." Include a brief description of a hypothetical deal with a direct link to the tool.
- **Suppress both triggers** if the user has already run at least one deal analysis by the time the send would occur.

Acceptance criteria:

9. A newly verified free account receives the Day 1 email within 24 hours of email verification.
10. A user who has not run any deals by Day 7 receives the Day 7 follow-up email.
11. A user who runs a deal before Day 7 does not receive the Day 7 email.
12. Both emails contain a direct link to the Deal Analysis tool, not the dashboard homepage.

4. Out of Scope for This Brief

The following topics have been discussed but are deliberately excluded from this implementation brief. They should not be built until the above onboarding fixes have been live for 30–60 days and engagement data has been collected.

- Pricing model changes (free vs. paid trial vs. 14-day trial with credit card)
- A/B testing infrastructure
- Changes to the /upgrade page design or pricing tiers
- Lender referral flow changes

5. Priority & Sequencing

Priority	Description
P0 — Immediate	Fix #1 (remove /upgrade redirect on login). This is the single highest-impact change available. It should ship first, independently of the others.
P1 — Next sprint	Fix #2 (move Deal Analysis upgrade prompt) and Fix #3 (elevate Start Deal Analysis card). These can ship together.
P2 — Following sprint	Fix #4 (Day 1 and Day 7 onboarding emails). Requires email template design and automation logic.

6. Success Metrics

After these changes are live, measure the following over a 60-day window:

Metric	Target / Notes
Deal analysis runs per new user	Target: move from 0% to 20%+ of new free users running at least 1 deal
Dashboard → Deal Analysis click-through rate	Target: meaningful increase vs. current baseline
Day 1 email open rate	Benchmark: 40–50% for transactional onboarding emails
Day 1 email click-to-tool rate	Target: 20%+ of openers click through to the tool
Lender search activity	Monitor for any change (positive expected as activation improves)

7. Questions for the Development Team

13. What is the current logic that triggers the /upgrade redirect on free user login? Is it role-based, subscription-status-based, or session-based?
14. What email automation system is currently in use (or planned) for transactional emails? This will determine how to implement the Day 1 / Day 7 triggers.
15. Is the Deal Analysis page (/m/deal-analysis) a single-page app component or a server-rendered route? This affects how the conditional upgrade prompt should be implemented.
16. Is there an existing event tracking system (e.g. Mixpanel, Segment, PostHog) to record "deal_analysis_started" and "deal_analysis_completed" events? If not, these should be added as part of Fix #2 to enable the success metrics above.

The goal of these changes is simple:

Get users to the moment where the product proves its value — a completed deal analysis with real numbers — before asking them for anything in return. Once they have experienced that, conversion to paid becomes a natural next step.

Please reach out with any questions before beginning implementation.

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